When an intermediate node has more than one child, we have several branches that we can traverse from it; when, instead, there is just one child connecting two nodes, they start somehow resembling a linked list: take for example the first three nodes from the root of figure 6.11, they encode the prefix “an”, and the search of any other string starting with ‘a’ but not followed by an ‘n’ couldn’t get anywhere in the tree.

In fact, turns out that an intermediate node is a branching point if it has more than one child: it means that the trie stores at least 2 keys sharing the common prefix corresponding to that node. If that’s the case, the node carries valuable information that we can't compress in any way.